



Newsletter

MISSION STATEMENT

The Grafton Historical Society is a non-profit 501(c)3 organization founded and operated by volunteers. We are dedicated to the preservation and sharing of Grafton area history.

GHS OFFICERS

Tom Krueger
President

Dave Antoine
Vice President

Debbie Krueger
Secretary

John Krueger
Treasurer

Nick Schanen
Director

Summer, 2024

Message from the President

We are now officially into the hot "lazy, hazy, crazy" days of summer, even though summer like weather actually arrived much earlier to Wisconsin than normal for our area. The warmer temperatures have been good for Chamber of Commerce events already completed, including the Zip Code Celebration event on May 30th and the Giro 'd Grafton Tour of America's Dairyland cycling event on June 15th. I am very pleased to report that the Grafton Historical Society was very visible at the Paramount Plaza on May 30th for the Zip Code Celebration Day and was able to serve as a collection point for public drop-off of items and artifacts to be placed into a 100 year time capsule. The time capsule will be buried in Veteran's Park at a ceremony later this summer. More details on this event will be forthcoming and you are all invited to attend.

Jim Wegner
Director

John Gassert
Director

Darrel Blank
Director

Phyllis Wiggins
Director

Emily Engstrom
Director

In other news at the Historical Society I would like to formally announce and welcome Phyllis Wiggins and Emily Engstrom to the Board of Directors. They were both appointed at the June 6th GHS meeting to fill two vacant positions. This now brings the board back to full strength at ten members. Thank you Phyllis and Emily for your interest and your willingness to become involved at the Board level.

Lastly, one of the Historical Society's larger goals over the last several years has been to find a permanent home for Grafton history. The plan to acquire building space for exhibits display, archives storage, office and resource areas has been quite cost-prohibitive for the GHS and little more than a dream. This year however, there are hints that progress on this front may be possible and we are very hopeful there will be more exciting news to report in the months ahead. Stay tuned and feel free to ask how you can help.

Working to discover, share and preserve" Grafton history.

Tom Krueger
GHS President

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GHS President



The Interurban Arrives

Life changed for many when, in 1906, a group of investors came together to promote an interurban line from Milwaukee to Sheboygan. The line, built and operated by the Milwaukee Northern Railroad Company, was open for business on October 29, 1907. The power house for the line was built in Port Washington and coal was unloaded directly from Lake Michigan steamers. It furnished light and power for the village of Grafton and several Milwaukee businesses.

The original line had 11 stops – Milwaukee, Cedarburg, Grafton, Port Washington, Cedar Grove and Sheboygan among them. Cars left on the hour from 6:00 a.m. to 10:00 p.m. with an “Owl” car leaving Milwaukee daily at 11:25 p.m. from 5th Street and Wells Avenue to bring home theatregoers.

The new interurban provided a speedy ride. It could travel at 50-55 m.p.h. with an average speed of 24 m.p.h. That meant a ride from Milwaukee to Sheboygan took only two hours and 35 minutes. Fares were sold by “books of miles.” A 100 mile book cost \$1.50. A 500 mile book was \$7.00 and a 1000 mile book was sold for \$13.00.

until an early hour this morning. The car leaving Milwaukee at 4:55 p.m. got as far as Highway 16, where it stalled by the banks of snow. Although the snowplows and a crew of men with shovels worked hard, it was nearly three o'clock in the morning before the train was extricated from the snowdrifts." The 24 passengers, tired and hungry, stopped for breakfast at the Washington House and then continued on their way.

In December 21, 1910, an interesting notice was posted, “Lost, a \$10 bill, last Thursday evening on way from Nic Schuh’s place, along railroad tracks to the Milwaukee Northern Station. Honest finder will please return to this office. Reward.” Higher stakes were involved in an incident on May 3, 1911. “The northside station of the Milwaukee-Northern Railroad was entered by burglars early Monday morning and \$300 in cash was taken from the safe. Someone familiar with the combination engineered the job.” The guilty party was apprehended one month later and sentenced to one year in the Green Bay Reformatory.

Even with the speed, economy and convenience, the business was not going well. In 1922 the Milwaukee Electric

The interurban provided great service to the area. According to records, "On August 3, 1910, the plumbers union of Milwaukee picnicked at Hilgen Spring Park with their families. They came over on the Milwaukee Northern."

A boon to the area, there nevertheless were many mishaps and near mishaps in the years of service. From an account of August 17, 1910, "Miss Lydia Bublitz, daughter of Mr. and Mrs. Theo Bublitz of this city, was struck and had a narrow escape of being instantly killed by the southbound interurban car last Thursday afternoon. She was walking on the tracks. As there is a large curve in the road bed, it is rather difficult for the motorman to see, and before the car could be stopped she was struck and hurled aside. She was taken to a Milwaukee hospital and recovered." Another incident occurred in 1916. There was a head-on collision of two Milwaukee Northern cars in Thiensville. Thirteen students of the Milwaukee School of Engineering, and the motorman were seriously injured. An account from the time explains that "Mr. Bickel, the motorman, was considered one of the best on the line. The report that he jumped from the cab is untrue, as he was hurled out by the force of the impact."

At times, animals fell victim too. Many cows and horses were hit by trains or killed when they happened upon downed power lines. Simply eating grass could also be dangerous. The following incident was recorded, "Two cows belonging to William Buch were poisoned when they ate grass along the right of way which had been sprayed to kill weeds. They were

Company purchased the Milwaukee Northern.

According to Charles Damaske, author of *Along the Right-of-Way to Sheboygan*, "The coming of the interurban was hailed with almost as much enthusiasm as the railroads were in pioneer days. For many years the line thrived with trains crowded all day long." The advent of the motor car and paved roads, however, caused patronage to drop and by 1947 plans were made to discontinue the line. An account described the last run on March 31, 1948 "There was little fanfare to mark its passage out of existence Sunday night but the interurban, or street car as it was commonly called, will be missed by many. Rockets were shot off along the tracks when the last car left the terminal in Milwaukee and along the route to Port Washington and back many bought tickets to take a final ride. At the controls of the last car was motorman Henry Pergande of Cedarburg. Frank Kittsley of Cedarburg who rode the car out of Milwaukee on October 28, 1907, was also a passenger on the last run to Port and back."

The interurban was replaced by the more flexible bus service but Damaske states, "There's a pang of regret when we think of rails that were laid by the venture and the hopes and dreams of men are to be torn up. Things are never the same. If they remained so there would be no progress – and yet the good old days when the interurban came to this countryside will not be forgotten. It marked an era that has left an indelible impression on the lives of people and communities."

Source: Along the Right-of-Way to Sheboygan, The Milwaukee Electric

treated by Dr. Wastrack and are out of danger.”

The interurban transportation was also subject to Wisconsin weather. A company official wrote on January 5, 1910, “We experienced an old time blizzard which began in the early afternoon and lasted

Railway & Light Company by Charles H. Damaske. 2001.



Willie Lee Brown

Willie Lee Brown, most often known as “Little Willie Brown” was credited with being one of the pioneering musicians of the Delta Blues genre.

Willie Brown was born to sharecropper parents near Clarksdale, Mississippi on August 6, 1900.

In his early teens, Brown worked on the Alex Peerman Plantation in rural Sunflower County. During these years, Brown began working on his distinctive guitar style and began



Brown and Patton traveled to Grafton to record for Paramount Studies in 1929-30. Brown recorded six titles under his own name.

During his career, Brown performed with other notable musicians such as Son House and Tommy Johnson and Memphis Minnie. Three of his highly rated solo performances were “M & O Blues”, “Make Me a Pallet on the Floor”, and “Future Blues”.

End of a Career

performing for other sharecroppers on the plantation.

Partnered with Willie Moore

Before long, he had teamed up with fellow bluesman Willie Moore to provide music on other plantations and on street corners. In their partnership, Brown preferred to be a “sideman” rather than playing the musical lead. World War I put a temporary end to their blues careers when both were drafted, but after the war, the two amateurs decided to become professional “bluesmen.”

Brown and Charley Patton

By the early 1920's Brown was performing with legendary Mississippi Bluesman Charley Patton.

In the 1940's Brown had given up his musical career when his partner House moved to New York but not before being recorded for the Library of Congress in 1941.

Brown returned to sharecropping, with his wife Annie Lee Brown. He died on December 30, 1952 from coronary thrombosis caused by alcoholism.

Willie Lee Brown was inducted into the Paramount Plaza Walk of Fame in 2022.



We're pleased to introduce our two new GHS board members!

Emily Engstrom

Our newest board member, Emily Engstrom, attended Cedarburg High School. She currently works for the United States Forest Service in Data Management/GIS. Emily's historical interests are varied. She helps coordinate a Facebook page for a cemetery in Southern Indiana. She also has an interest in African American history in the Midwest. Professionally, she was the secretary of the board of the Lawrence County Historical and Genealogy Society in Bedford, Indiana and chair of their collections committee. She was also vice-president of the Friends of Spring Mill State Park board in Mitchell, Indiana.

Phyllis Wiggins

I'm Phyllis Marie Wiggins, PhD. I've lived in Grafton for four years and originally hail from Chicago, Illinois. I moved to Wisconsin in 1989 but left very quickly to join the United States Army during Desert Storm in November, 1990. I always considered Wisconsin my home. My momma used to say I would do anything to get out of Chicago! She had to watch me closely because I joined the first urban 4-H club just to get to the State Fair and get to the "country." Unfortunately, I dragged my little brother and five nieces and nephews with me! Those were the good old days. I was never a good history student. In fact, I struggled with history classes because my teacher droned on and on with dates and facts that never seemed to reflect my interests. It was during my tour in Germany, that I realized World War II was more than a Grimms Fairy Tale about Hanzel and Gretl. I took every opportunity to visit historical sites because I began to *experience* history as something more than just far away imaginary lands in books.

As a Board member, I want to help other people *experience* history – especially young people and people of Color. I want Grafton's history to be so alive that others enjoy it and understand it from a personal perspective. History is more than dates and facts. It's someone's life, someone's story, a people's experience, a collection of songs, a shared memory, a collective laugh, a remembered smile, or a heartfelt journey. I want to bring those things to others in ways that are contextually memorable!

Thank you for having me on this Board. I never imagined I would be on a Historical Society Board. I hope I live up to the expectations of each of you and serve the community well!

Oh, and please, call me Phyllis!





Help Save Our History

The GHS has recently been gifted a historic picture of the Wisconsin Chair Factory by the Grafton Chamber of Commerce. The painting is by M.P. Gossens, dated 1915, and was discovered in the Wisconsin Chair Company building before the structure was demolished. This

artwork is very important because the chair factory was central to putting Grafton on the map in the Blues music industry.

The chair factory was built in 1848, the same year Wisconsin became a state. It operated as a furniture manufacturer until 1873. By the early 1900s, the plant was turning out more than 40 dozen chairs daily.

On December 14, 1916, the Wisconsin Chair Company founded the New York Recording Laboratories and began restructuring the factory to manufacture 78-rpm records for use on phonographs the company also produced. The first record made in Grafton was created from a New York City studio master on June 19, 1917. The New York Recording Labs continued operations until 1932, with more than 100 employees working in its record-pressing and shipping facilities. Records were produced for the Wisconsin Chair Company's Paramount, Puritan, Broadway and Famous labels as well as dozens of other labels for national retailers.

The Great Depression forced the company to discontinue leasing recording studios in New York and Chicago. Instead, it operated its own Grafton studio from 1929 to 1932. Hundreds of Wisconsin and out-of-state musicians recorded here. Among them were blues legends such as Charlie Patton, Skip James, Blind Blake, Son House, Willie Brown and Big Bill Broonzy.

The last record was made in July 1932 by the Mississippi Sheiks. The building was demolished in 1938.

Time has taken its toll on the painting since 1938 and it needs to be restored. The GHS has contacted an art conservator and has received an estimate of \$2,000 to bring the painting back to life. We will begin fundraising soon, so that the work can be completed and the painting is available for the public to view. If you would like to send a donation to help get this work underway, mail your check, made out to the Grafton Historical Society to P.O. Box 481, Grafton, WI 53024.

Thank you!



**THE GRAFTON HISTORICAL SOCIETY
PRESENTS:**

Did You Know They Were From Wisconsin?

The Grafton Historical Society welcomes back popular speaker Jim Heinz for a special presentation on famous people, from all walks of life, who were from Wisconsin.

From the man who was bigger than Elvis, to a leader of the resistance to Hitler, to the world's greatest athlete to a man you all once knew and tried to forget, Jim Heinz will entertain you with stories of people you may never have suspected were from right here in Wisconsin.



Sponsoring partner:



**Thursday,
September 5th**

**6:00 p.m.
Rose Harms
Legion Post
1540 13th Avenue
Grafton**

**Free and open to the
public.**

**Refreshments and
Cash Bar**

**GRAFTON HISTORICAL
SOCIETY**

P.O. Box 481
Grafton, WI 53024

Website:
www.graftonareahistory.org

Email:
info@graftonareahistory.org



**THE GRAFTON HISTORICAL SOCIETY
PRESENTS...**

THE PESHTIGO FIRE

In October, 1871 America's deadliest wildfire leveled the town of Peshtigo, killing 2,500. Hear the survivor stories of heroics and tragedies from that fateful day.



Sponsoring partner:



David Siegel, retired captain from the Green Bay Metro Fire Department, has worked for several years at the Belgian Heritage Center to commemorate and memorialize the 1871 fire. He is an avid history buff and author of a book on the early history of the Green Bay Fire Department.

**Thursday,
October 3rd**

6:00 p.m.

**Rose Harms
Legion Post
1540 13th Avenue**

**Free and open to
the public.**

**Refreshments
and Cash Bar**

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**The Underground Railroad
Presentation Draws Large Crowd**

It was nearly standing room only at the Rose Harms Legion hall for the recent presentation on the Underground Railroad in Wisconsin. Dave Warren, Underground Railroad expert from the Milton House, (the last certified Underground Railroad Station in Wisconsin) told intense stories of escapes making their way through Wisconsin, and the gripping event that put the state front and center in the nation's fight over the abolition of slavery.



Zip Code Day in Grafton

Great weather and a perfect location drew many people to Grafton's Zip Code day on May 30, 2024 in downtown Grafton. Sponsored by the Grafton Chamber of Commerce, the event brought together many local businesses and groups. Historical Society board members were on hand to greet visitors to the GHS table and answer questions about the group and upcoming programs.

SCENES FROM THE PAST

Enjoy a "scene from the past" contributed to the News Graphic newspaper by the Grafton Historical Society each month. The scenes are featured in the fourth Tuesday of the month edition. It's a part of our mission to share Grafton area history. If you have a vintage photo that you would like to share, please contact us at: info@graftonareahistory.org.

DO YOU KNOW?

With this issue we'd like to continue our "Mystery Item" feature. If you have an idea what this item might be contact us at: info@graftonareahistory.org. If you have an item that you need help identifying and would like to submit it for a future newsletter edition, we'd be happy to include it.



DID YOU KNOW?

If you said that this **Mystery Item** from the last issue of our Newsletter was ...

An Early Typewriter

This early typewriter was followed some years later by the first commercially successful typewriter, developed in Milwaukee, by Christopher Sholes and Carlos Glidden in 1867. It was known as the Remington No. 1. It was put on the market on July 1, 1873.



We're happy to report that the GHS membership is growing! This year we have already registered many new individual, family and lifetime memberships.

If you are not already a member, we invite you to join us to Discover, Preserve, and Share Grafton history.

<http://www.graftonareahistory.org>

This message was sent to dtkrueger@wi.rr.com by info@griftonareahistory.org
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